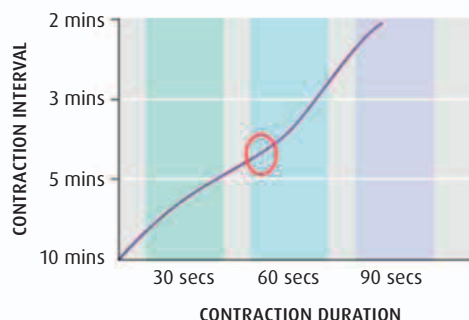


WHEN TO GO TO THE HOSPITAL OR STAY AT HOME

Timing contractions and helping decide when to go to the hospital is a key part of your role.

Your partner may be increasingly preoccupied, which means you may need to judge when to leave for the hospital. If contractions are irregular (albeit painful), and she can talk through them, it's best to stay at home. Once contractions are five minutes apart, intense, and last for around 60 seconds, head in. It may sound obvious, but factor in your distance from the hospital, and leave earlier if it's far away.



SUDDEN BIRTH

Very occasionally, labor moves so quickly that there isn't enough time to get to the hospital. If you are with your partner and she feels an overwhelming urge to push, you will need to take an active role.

» Help your partner stay calm. Call your doctor or 911 so that paramedics can be sent to you.

» Turn up the heat, if it's cold, and ask your partner which room she would like to be in. Gather about four clean towels and two or three blankets. Fold two towels and place them beneath your partner's bottom. Find a plastic bag or container that doesn't have any holes in it for the placenta to be placed in.

The birth itself

» Call 911 again and the operator will stay on the line and advise you. (Speakerphone is useful, since you'll need your hands free.) If you can see the baby's head, support it as it crowns. Check the cord, and if this is compressed around the baby before he is born, untangle it if it is loose enough to do so; if it isn't loose enough to free easily, leave it as it is and unwrap it once the baby is completely out.

» Encourage your partner to push gently with each contraction. Once the head, shoulders, and finally the body are delivered, place the baby on your partner's belly. Leave the cord intact—it should be long enough for you to put the baby on your partner's abdomen. Dry the baby, then keep him warm with a towel and blanket. Don't pull on the cord and don't try to cut it or clamp it in any way. The cord will continue to pump blood into the baby for 10 minutes or so after the birth, then it will stop pulsating. You can leave it attached even then.

» Your partner will have one or more contractions to deliver the placenta and membranes. This should come out in one piece with the cord and the membranes of the amniotic sac attached. There'll be some bleeding, which is normal. Put the placenta in a plastic bag for the doctor to check. Keep your baby warm, listen to the paramedics, and stay calm.

Soothing touch A lower back massage can be relaxing in the early stages of labor, and may be especially welcome if contractions are causing lower back pain.

